Whose Land, Whose Water?

Student sheet · Première générale, LVA B1+, LVB B1 · bac pro and CFA · CAP A2 route

Official page: https://itineraires-destinations.fr/whose-land-whose-water/

Eight lessons of 55 minutes, each timed for 52 minutes. Lesson 8 is the final task: a citizens' hearing and an open letter.

Name: _____ Class: _____

Central question: when a government makes promises to Indigenous peoples, who decides what happens to the land and the water, and how can citizens check whether those promises are kept?

Listening protocol: listen once for the main message, note keywords, listen again for details, then read the support text. Label your notes H (heard), R (read afterwards), I (inferred) or ? (unsure).

The paintings, videos, images and visible answer keys are on the official pages. Make two flashcards in every lesson.

Lesson 1. Look Before You Judge

Goal: I can distinguish what I see from what I think, and explain one possible relationship between art, land and water.

Student text

First Nations, Inuit and Métis are distinct Indigenous peoples recognised in Canada's Constitution. These names do not describe one single culture.

Jim Logan and Norval Morrisseau offer different artistic perspectives. Logan's painting shows a boy and a dog in a village. Morrisseau's painting connects a loon, a fish and a sun through lines.

A painting can invite an interpretation without proving a geographical location or a social condition. We should say what we see before explaining what it might mean.

Building your vocabulary

Expression	Meaning
foreground	the part nearest the viewer
background	the part furthest from the viewer
outline	a line around a shape
relationship	a connection between people or beings
stewardship	care for a place and its future
interpretation	an explanation of possible meaning

Worksheet A. Observation and interpretation

Complete the table.

Statement	Observation or interpretation?	What supports it?

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A boy is shown with a dog.		
The boy might feel lonely.		
The village is certainly on a reserve.		
The colours are bright.		

Then write:

1. In the foreground, I can see _____.

2. In the background, there are _____.

3. The boy might _____ because _____.

4. The painting does not prove _____.

Worksheet B. Relationships

1. Name three elements: _____ / _____ / _____.

2. What joins them? _____.

3. The lines may suggest _____.

4. One question I would ask about this painting is _____.

Written record

First Nations, Inuit and Métis are distinct Indigenous peoples. In art analysis, I distinguish observation from interpretation. Morrisseau's connecting lines may suggest relationships between living beings. A painting alone does not prove a community's location or living conditions.

Homework

Write 60 to 80 words comparing the paintings. Include two observations, two cautious interpretations and one question.

LVB support:

Both paintings show…
However…
The lines might…
I would like to know…

Flashcards: make two cards from today's word box.

Lesson 2. 1969: The White Paper and the Red Paper

Goal: I can explain the difference between equal treatment and the protection of existing rights.

Student text

In 1969, Prime Minister Pierre Elliott Trudeau's government proposed the White Paper. Jean Chrétien, the minister responsible for Indian Affairs, presented it.

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The government argued that removing separate legal status would promote equality. Its proposals included repealing the Indian Act, removing Indian status and transferring responsibilities to the provinces. Reserve land would become property owned by bands or their members.

Many First Nations leaders rejected the proposal. They argued that equal citizenship should not remove treaty rights or the federal government's responsibilities.

In 1970, the Indian Association of Alberta presented Citizens Plus, known as the Red Paper. Opposition led to the withdrawal of the White Paper.

Building your vocabulary

• repeal: officially cancel a law;

• status: a recognised legal position;

• treaty: a formal agreement;

• withdraw: take back a proposal;

• equality: equal worth, rights or treatment;

• collective: belonging to a group.

Listening worksheet

First listening:

1. Is the report mainly about a political leader, a dam or a sports team? _____.

Second listening:

2. Name: _____.

3. Age when he became association leader: _____.

4. Book title: _____.

5. Which word reverses the idea of a "Just Society"? _____.

Restitution:

The report presents _____.
He became _____ at the age of _____.
His book title challenges _____ because _____.

Comparison worksheet

Question	White Paper	Red Paper
What did its supporters want?		
What did they say about equality?		
What would happen to existing rights?		

Finish:

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The disagreement was not simply about whether people should be equal. It was about _____.

Written record

The 1969 White Paper proposed removing Indian status and repealing the Indian Act. Many First Nations leaders rejected it because they wanted citizenship without losing treaty rights. The 1970 Red Paper expressed this position as “Citizens Plus”. Strong opposition led to withdrawal of the proposal.

Homework

Write 80 to 100 words:

Why did many First Nations leaders reject the White Paper?

Use argued that, was going to and however.

Flashcards: make two cards from today’s word box.

Lesson 3. Rivers into Reservoirs

Goal: I can explain why an agreement may bring benefits and losses at the same time.

Student text

Quebec announced the James Bay hydroelectric project in 1971. Cree and Inuit opposition, legal action and negotiations helped lead to the James Bay and Northern Quebec Agreement in 1975.

The project produced electricity, but reservoirs also changed hunting grounds and access to land. The teaching dossier describes the relocation of Fort George residents to Chisasibi and concerns about mercury in fish.

The agreement also supported institutions and public services. These outcomes should not be reduced to “everyone benefited” or “nothing improved”. Different communities and speakers may assess the agreement differently.

Building your vocabulary

• dam: a structure that holds back river water;

• reservoir: an artificial lake storing water;

• relocate: move to another place;

• compensation: money or another response to a loss;

• autonomy: the ability to make decisions;

• discharge: the volume of water passing a point over time.

Listening worksheet A

1. Project announced by: _____.

2. Year: _____.

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3. Peoples whose involvement was initially missing: _____.

4. One action they took: _____.

5. One negotiated benefit: _____.

6. One lasting cost: _____.

Restitution:

> The project was announced in…
> The report explains that…
> Negotiations brought…
> However…

Listening worksheet B

Record only what you can identify.

Speaker or community	Benefit mentioned	Concern mentioned

Then write:

> The speakers do / do not give exactly the same assessment because _____.

Do not invent a speaker's name. Write "one interviewee" if necessary.

Cause-and-effect worksheet

Complete:

1. Reservoirs changed _____.

2. Concerns about erosion contributed to _____.

3. Mercury concerns affected _____.

4. The agreement supported _____.

5. A figure in cubic metres per second describes _____, not speed.

Written record

> The 1975 James Bay agreement followed conflict and negotiation over hydroelectric development. It brought compensation and institutions, while the project also transformed land and community life. We must identify whose assessment we are reporting. Discharge is measured in cubic metres per second; it is not the same as current speed.

Homework

Write a 90 to 110-word museum information panel:

> James Bay: electricity, agreement and lasting change.

Include one benefit, one loss and a named source. Do not invent first-person testimony.

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Replay the second video and add one accurately attributed viewpoint.

Flashcards: make two cards from today’s word box.

Lesson 4. Dams Today: Muskrat Falls and Site C

Goal: I can report a campaigner’s concern without confusing a prediction, a quotation and a measured outcome.

Student text

At Muskrat Falls in Labrador, campaigners raised concerns about the effects of flooding on water, fish and traditional activities. In 2016, Inuk artist Billy Gauthier took part in a hunger strike.

At Site C in British Columbia, West Moberly leadership challenged the project and proposed alternatives. Supporters argued that the dam would provide electricity.

These cases involve different peoples and territories. Inuit and Innu are not interchangeable names. A campaigner’s prediction about contamination is also not the same as a later measurement.

Building your vocabulary

• downstream: further along a river’s direction of flow;

• campaigner: someone working publicly for change;

• methylmercury: a harmful form of mercury;

• alternative: another possible choice;

• prediction: a statement about what may happen;

• measured outcome: a result established through observation or measurement.

Listening worksheet A

1. Speaker: _____.

2. His protest method: _____.

3. What change does he want? _____.

4. Which family activity matters to his daughter? _____.

5. What future does he want to protect? _____.

Listening worksheet B

1. Speaker and community: _____.

2. What promise does he say was made? _____.

3. What decision does he criticise? _____.

4. Name two alternatives: _____ / _____.

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Comparison worksheet

Question	Muskrat Falls	Site C
Main concern reported		
Requested action		
Evidence type	testimony / prediction / measurement	testimony / prediction / measurement

Written record

The Muskrat Falls and Site C reports present concerns about health, territory and decision-making. Campaigners may support some forms of development while opposing a particular project or method. We distinguish testimony, predictions and measured outcomes. We also identify the nation or community concerned.

Homework

Write 100 to 120 words:

Why can the expression “clean energy” require explanation?

Use one example, one attributed viewpoint and one sentence beginning “Although”.

Flashcards: make two cards from today’s word box.

Lesson 5. Pipelines on Unceded Land

Goal: I can explain disagreement about a project without assuming that one speaker represents everyone.

Student text

Coastal GasLink and Trans Mountain generated disagreement among and within First Nations.

In the Coastal GasLink dispute, elected councils signed agreements, while hereditary leadership opposing the project stressed responsibilities connected with wider traditional territory. These positions should be attributed carefully.

The 1997 Delgamuukw decision is important for understanding Aboriginal title and oral history. It should not be described as a simple final award of the entire disputed territory to particular individuals.

Consultation means meaningful discussion and consideration of concerns. Consent means agreement. These are different concepts, and their legal implications depend on the circumstances.

For an optional current update, the November 2026 federal budget records an offer of a collective 15% Trans Mountain ownership share to 128 Indigenous groups. This is an offer, not evidence that every group agreed or that the transfer was completed.

Building your vocabulary

• consent: agreement;

• consultation: meaningful discussion before or during decision-making;

• elected council: a council selected through an election;

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• hereditary leadership: leadership under a nation's own inherited governance traditions;

• injunction: a court order requiring or prohibiting an action;

• stake: an ownership share.

Listening worksheet A

1. What action followed the court order? _____.

2. What does Justin Trudeau say has changed from the past? _____.

3. What principle does he also invoke? _____.

4. Why does John Horgan defend the process? _____.

5. Whose position does lawyer Peter Grant present? _____.

Listening worksheet B

1. What is the watch house intended to protect? _____.

2. What have some other First Nations signed? _____.

3. What economic concern does one chief express? _____.

4. Does the report show agreement among all First Nations? _____.

Comparison worksheet

Claim	Who makes it?	Source	What needs qualification?
Agreements support the project.			
Wider territorial responsibilities remain disputed.			
Ownership can bring benefits.			

Written record

The pipeline reports show different positions among First Nations leaders and communities. Agreements signed by some representatives do not prove agreement by everyone. Consultation and consent are different concepts. We must attribute claims and avoid oversimplifying Aboriginal title.

Homework

Complete four rows:

Argument	Supporting evidence	Speaker/source	Limitation or question

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Use at least one argument supporting a project and one questioning it.

Flashcards: make two cards from today's word box.

Lesson 6. Promises Kept, Promises Broken

Goal: I can separate a missed deadline from later progress and compare figures with the correct scope.

Student text

In 2015, Justin Trudeau promised to end long-term drinking-water advisories on First Nations reserves by March 2021.

The official page consulted for this sequence gives a snapshot dated 10 September 2026. It records 158 long-term advisories lifted since November 2015 and 38 active advisories in 36 communities.

These figures concern long-term advisories on public systems on reserves. They do not describe every water problem affecting every Indigenous person in Canada.

New advisories can be added. A cumulative count of lifted advisories is therefore not simply a count taken from one unchanged starting list. Progress and failure to meet the deadline can both be reported.

Building your vocabulary

• pledge: a formal promise;

• deadline: a date by which something should be done;

• advisory: an official warning or instruction;

• lift an advisory: officially end it;

• cumulative: added together over time;

• scope: what a statement or dataset includes.

Listening worksheet A

Remember: this report concerns 2020.

1. Why were Neskantaga residents away from home? _____.

2. How long had the advisory lasted at that point? _____.

3. What deadline had been promised? _____.

4. One reported reason for delay: _____.

Listening worksheet B

Speaker	Main assessment
RoseAnne Archibald	
David Chartrand	
Lynne Groulx	

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Restitution:

> The speakers do not assess progress in the same way.
> One stresses…
> Another acknowledges…
> A third asks for…

Listening worksheet C

1. What accountability tool is discussed? _____.

2. Which public-service areas should it help compare? _____.

3. What obstacle is mentioned? _____.

4. Is an action “underway” necessarily “complete”? _____.

Dated evidence worksheet

Item	Answer
Original promise	
Original deadline	
Snapshot date	
Lifted since November 2015	
Still active	
Communities affected	
Dataset scope	
One limitation	

Written record

> The drinking-water deadline was March 2021. The retrieved official snapshot, dated 10 September 2026, records 158 long-term advisories lifted since November 2015 and 38 active advisories in 36 communities. This shows progress, but not completion. The figures concern a defined category of public systems on reserves, not all water insecurity.

Homework

Write a 90 to 120-word fact-check:

> Claim: “The water promise was fully completed.”

Include the promise, a dated source, two relevant figures and a limitation.

A valid conclusion is:

> The deadline was missed, although substantial progress was recorded.

Students may use a different justified formulation. “Partly kept” is not the only acceptable verdict.

Flashcards: make two cards from today’s word box.

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Lesson 7. The Grizzlies: Youth, Land and Hope

Goal: I can explain how an interview presents youth agency and distinguish an introduction from a full film review.

Student text

The Grizzlies is a Canadian film directed by Miranda de Pencier. It is based on a true story involving young people and a lacrosse team in Kugluktuk, in what is now Nunavut.

The interview presents young Inuit people as participants with their own relationships, abilities and ambitions. It should not be reduced to a story in which an outsider simply “saves” a community.

Today you are studying a synopsis and an interview. Unless you have watched the film, your task is to introduce it and analyse the interview, not to claim knowledge of scenes you have not seen.

Building your vocabulary

• agency: the ability to act and influence events;

• resilience: the ability to respond to difficulty;

• reclaim: take back or strengthen something valued;

• give up: stop trying;

• stand up for: defend;

• synopsis: a short account of a story.

Listening worksheet

1. What kind of story does the director describe? _____.

2. What does the teacher say about the effect students had on him? _____.

3. What future-oriented message do you identify? _____.

4. Which detail shows young people’s agency? _____.

5. Which answer is directly heard, and which is your interpretation? _____.

Comparison worksheet

Question	Logan’s painting	Interview about The Grizzlies
How are young people represented?		
What suggests connection or isolation?		
What should we avoid assuming?		

Written record

The interview about The Grizzlies highlights relationships, youth agency and hope. Playing together can create support, but one story does not represent every Inuit experience. An interview-based introduction must not pretend to be a review of an unseen film.

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Homework

Write 120 to 150 words:

An introduction to The Grizzlies based on its synopsis and interview.

Include what you know, what the interview suggests and what you cannot yet judge.

Prepare the final hearing using one dossier from lesson 8.

Flashcards: make two cards from today's word box.

Lesson 8. A Citizens' Hearing and an Open Letter

Goal: I can present sourced evidence, respond to a question and make a proportionate recommendation.

Building your vocabulary

• evidence: information supporting a claim;

• recommendation: a proposed course of action;

• limitation: something the evidence does not establish;

• accountability: being required to explain decisions and results;

• proportionate: appropriate to the evidence and problem.

Evidence card

Name: _____ Case: _____

1. The proposal, pledge or disputed commitment was: _____.

2. It was made by: _____.

3. Date: _____.

4. First fact: _____.

5. Source and date: _____.

6. Second fact: _____.

7. Source and date: _____.

8. A different viewpoint: _____.

9. A limitation: _____.

10. Our recommendation: _____.

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Written record

My case concerns _____. My strongest evidence is _____, from _____. One limitation is _____. My recommendation is _____ because _____.

Homework

Finish the letter.

Then complete:

• One claim I improved: _____.

• One source I can identify: _____.

• One language feature I used successfully: _____.

• One question still open: _____.

Flashcards: make two cards from today’s word box.

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